in the shadows of my mind

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64285684.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra)

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by artemiswords

Summary

how does one mourn a monster?

(in which catra learns that helping to save the universe by kissing her girlfriend did not cure her of all of her ghosts)

Notes

wow it's been a minute (5 years) since my last she-ra fic uh

some time last year i did my first full she-ra rewatch and naturally went a little insane again, so i started this but just when i was about to finish it arcane took over my brain, but then this year i got a catradora tattoo and was like i should finish that little fic i started... and here we are :-)

this rewatch made me think a lot more about the themes of the abuse cycles depicted and catra's mommy issues so i felt compelled to write something that explored her feelings post shadow weaver's death.

i also dearly missed writing fic... i'm def rusty but thank you everyone who has read my stuff throughout the years. i still appreciate and and read all the comments even if i don't reply to all of them ^_^

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra found herself in the greenhouse of Bright Moon. She didn't mean to go there, but walking the empty corridors of the castle at night, confused and still sleepy after a nightmare, she needed some air. Outside, at the gardens, it was hard to not follow the floating steps up to the small greenhouse.

She hadn't had a nightmare in a long time, not even a bad dream since everything changed again. Since the Heart, since a confession and a kiss she had craved for since before she understood what bodies could crave for. Peaceful sleep nights curled next to Adora's warmth was all she knew in the few weeks since that fateful day. Mostly dreamless nights, although some with unremarkable yet still nice dreams. It was new. So much was new, recently. Catra hadn't known she could feel that much happiness, or that she was even allowed to.

But alas, helping to save the universe and dating the girl she loved didn't cure her of all her demons and ghosts, apparently.

An explosion of shadows and fire, a scarred face disintegrating in flames, "You're welcome."

Catra shuddered and braced herself, dream and memories mixing together.

She inspected the environment with her eyes. She knew that was the place where Shadow Weaver had spent most of her time when she was in Bright Moon, as Glimmer had mentioned she used the plants for her stupid magic, or whatever. It was weird to imagine Shadow Weaver tenderly caring for, well, anything. Catra hadn't know she had hobbies, but she'd never really stopped to think what she did in her free time. She thought she just sat around planning new ways of manipulating people, or floated around creepily in the shadows.

The garden looked unkept and overgrown. Adora's magic probably had some influence on that. One part of the roof was still

destroyed, with moonlight coming through and making the scattered glass on the ground shine. Reconstructions were underway but this part of the castle wasn't essential and would probably only be dealt with later.

Catra walked in from the door slowly, careful to not step on glass. She wasn't sure what she was looking for, if anything. Shadow Weaver was gone.

It wasn't fair that even then she could still haunt Catra. She hadn't allowed herself to think about her or their last moments. She was busy with better things, anyway.

She was about to turn back and go back to Adora's room — no, their room now, — when she stepped on something metallic and looked down. Under some rubble, shiny, a familiar looking star shaped object. Catra crouched down and picked it up. It looked just like that old badge Shadow Weaver had asked her to get, but a different color in the middle. This one was intact, very different from the broken one in her old cell she left there before abandoning her.

Catra got up slowly. She considered throwing it back on the ground, stepping on it until it broke apart, but was surprised to not find that old anger inside of her, even though looking at that in her hands hurt. She didn't even know if it was also hers, it could belong to anyone in Glimmer's family.

She inhaled sharply, swallowing a lump in her throat.

That was so stupid, why did it matter? Why was she even there at that hour?

"Catra?"

Catra snapped around with a jump to find a sleepy Adora at the greenhouse's door.

Adora's eyes widened seeing whatever her expression was, so she turned back around, bringing a hand up to wipe at her now wet

eyes.

“You scared me.” Catra tried to say, but her voice shook.

In a quick moment Adora was already by her, arms wrapping around her sides from behind her.

“What’s wrong?” Adora rested her head on Catra’s shoulder.

“Nightmare.”

Adora held her closer.

“Shadow Weaver?”

Catra blinked hard, her entire body tense. Adora tugged at her to turn around, which she obliged, while still holding her.

“It’s okay, you’re okay now.” Adora rubbed small circles on her back.

It was that gentleness that Adora so easily gave her that broke Catra. Unable to hold it in anymore, she cried, burying her face in Adora’s chest as her body went limp. Adora tightened her hold on her to keep her in place.

“It’s okay, I’ve got you. She can’t hurt us anymore.”

“I know, it’s not—” Catra sobbed.

She straightened up and looked back at Adora.

“She’s gone. She’s really gone.”

Adora stared at her for a moment as understanding dawned on her.

“Oh, Catra.” She said, her own eyes getting tearful.

She felt like a fool.

“Why do I still care? I hate her. *She* hated me. So why did she—” Catra sobbed again.

Adora held her again, hugging her tightly. Catra hugged back this time, the stupid sorcerer object falling from her hands as she clutched at Adora’s pajamas shirt.

“It’s okay that you care, Catra.” Adora said after a while. “It’s okay to grieve her.”

Catra breathed in and out, slowly calming down.

“It’s stupid.”

“No. It’s human.” Adora pressed a kiss to Catra’s temple.

“I’m a magicat.”

Adora snorted. “And I’m an alien from outer space.”

Catra laughed weakly. She pulled apart from the hug to look at Adora again.

“Idiot.”

“Wanna go back to bed?”

Catra nodded.

Adora brought her hands to cup the side of Catra’s face gently. Just staring at her eyes like that made her feel better. Adora scratched behind her ear and she leaned into the touch.

“I love you.” Adora said with a small smile. “You know you can wake me up when you have a nightmare, right?”

Catra smiled, flushing at the sound of those words. It still felt surreal to hear them.

She nodded again.

“Promise you’ll wake me up if it happens again?”

“I promise.” Catra replied easily. “I love you too.”

Adora’s eyes shined and Catra almost leaned in for a kiss, but they should really get going, she thought.

“Let’s go before you get glass in your socks.” Catra said.

Adora blinked, then looked down around them.

“Oh, shit.”

“You put your hair back up in a ponytail but didn’t put your boots on?”

“I was half asleep, okay? My ponytail helps me focus.” Adora smiled. She brought a hand down to hold Catra’s. “C’mon, it’s cold out here.”

Catra slept the rest of the night with no new nightmares or old memories. Adora held her tighter than usual, which she didn’t mind at all.

She woke up first, but didn’t move, enjoying the weight of Adora’s arm over her and her slow breathes on her collarbone. Soft daylight spilled through. She knew Adora would wake up soon, as she did every morning, chirpy and excited for another day.

She’d thought the previous night had just been a fluke, but there was still a heaviness in her chest. She also knew Adora would probably want to inquiry her about it, which she didn’t mind that much, but she wasn’t sure how to explain what she was feeling.

After coming back to Etheria and joining the princesses, Catra never thought Shadow Weaver would’ve changed, or that they’d

grow close somehow. She read right through the old woman's power hungry intentions, and almost lost Adora in the process. She wasn't naive anymore. But maybe a small part of her still hoped things could've been different one day, that part of her that she'd tried to stomp down so many times, but never could get rid of. Catra always cared too much. She didn't see that as a weakness anymore, but anything in relation to Shadow Weaver made her feel like a scared and stupid little kid.

Adora shifted slightly.

Catra brought one hand to Adora's head and slowly ran her finger's through her loose hair. It took another moment for Adora to move again. She shifted an arm to hug Catra, then looked up at her, blinking away sleepiness.

"Morning, sleepyhead."

"Catra." Adora said, almost surprised, smiling big.

"Adora." Catra mirrored her expression. "Expected someone else?" She raised an eyebrow.

"No." Adora snorted. "I'm just happy you're here. Don't disappear in the middle of the night again, okay? It freaked me out."

Adora's eyebrows knitted in worry. Catra caressed the side of her face, rubbing a thumb against her cheek.

"I won't do that again." She said, remembering the last time she sneaked out in the middle of the night, when she was so sure Adora would never in a million years want her in this way. "I promised, remember?"

Adora's worry melted away. She moved up to rest her weight on one elbow, hovering over Catra for a moment, before leaning down to kiss her.

Kissing Adora felt so natural to Catra and her body as if it was something she had done for all of her life, not just for the last

month or so. Often she still kicked herself in her mind for all the time she had wasted staying in the Horde, when she could've been doing this for so much longer, but the thought that she could still do it for the rest of her life to make up for it was enough to soothe her. That and Adora's soft lips, her fingers running through the back of Catra's hair, her weight on top of Catra.

Too soon, Adora pulled away. Catra sighed and Adora rested her forehead on hers.

"Are you feeling better today?" Adora asked.

Catra opened her eyes to meet Adora's soft stare and rosy cheeks. She nodded.

"Do you wanna talk about last night?"

"No." Catra said, reflexively.

Adora didn't look upset by that. She pressed a kiss to the corner of Catra's mouth then sat up in bed, holding one of her hands.

"Okay. Breakfast, then?"

"I think I'll skip it today, but you should go."

"But you love breakfast with Glimmer and Bow." Adora pouted.

"I *tolerate* breakfast with your friends." Catra said, but her smile betrayed her pretended annoyance.

Adora gasped.

"They're your friends too! If they hear you saying that they're literally going to start sobbing."

"Always so sentimental with princesses." Catra laughed.

Adora pulled her up by her arms to make her sit up, who didn't struggle *that* much to try to remain lying down.

“C’mon, Catra!” Adora giggled.

She wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck.

“Ugh, I just wanted to stay in bed all day.”

“No sulking allowed in Bright Moon.”

“It’s not sulking.”

“Are you sure you don’t wanna talk about last night?” Adora asked carefully after a moment.

Catra took a deep breath, thinking for a moment.

“I just need to be alone in the dark and shove it all down, then I’ll be good.”

“Catra, no.” Adora pulled them apart, holding her by the shoulders. “That’s not healthy.”

“But we did that all the time growing up.”

Adora raised an eyebrow.

Catra shrugged.

“The way we were raised in the Horde is not a good example of what to do for our mental health, Catra.” Adora said. “It’s like… the very opposite!”

She couldn’t deny that.

Adora held her hands.

“It took me so long to also not default to ‘hide your weaknesses’ mode here. But talking helps. I’d talk with Bow and Glimmer all the time. And I think Bow also mentioned therapy helps?”

“What’s that?”

"I think it's like a doctor, but for your mind? Bow said you go to a therapist and talk things out then they say some magic words and with time you feel better."

"So like a spell?" Catra frowned. Etherian magic was always so weird. "Is that some type of princess?"

"No, okay, not really *magic* magic words… it's like they know what to say?" Adora looked as confused as Catra was. "I'm not sure, honestly, I never got around to it. But talking about things is a big part of feeling better, Bow said."

Catra sighed. "Can't you just use your She-Ra healing to erase all my childhood trauma?"

"She-Ra is powerful, but not *that* powerful, I don't think." Adora shook her head sadly.

"Boo." Catra pouted. Adora looked at her expectantly. "Fiiine. Let's go eat breakfast, I guess."

"Morning, Bow." Adora said, siting at the table they usually shared in the kitchen.

"Good morning, guys!" Bow smiled from his seat. He was spreading some vibrant colored jelly on a piece of toast.

Catra was still amazed over all the different food there was in Bright Moon. Even though she had food besides ration bars in the Horde, it was never *that* good, and there were barely any smuggled from Bright Moon. And fine, maybe she did enjoy it *a little bit* to spend time with Glimmer and Bow now, but she didn't need to feed their egos with that knowledge.

"Where's Sparkles?" Catra asked, siting next to Adora.

Adora poured some coffee on Catra's mug then started piling up her own plate with food.

"Ooh, chocolate muffins!" She exclaimed and placed one in front of Catra.

"She left early for Mystacor." Bow said. "She wanted to check on Micah and how they were doing up there. She's been stressing out about the celebration party Bright Moon is having so I thought it'd be a good break for her."

"Oh yeah, that's soon right?" Adora said.

"Did you guys think of a better name for it yet?" Catra asked.

She took a sip of the coffee as she held her mug with both hands, enjoying its warmth.

"What's wrong with The First Liberation from the Evil Horde Celebration Party?" Bow asked.

"Don't you think it's a *little* too long?"

"It is a bit of a mouthful." Adora considered, mouth full of food.

"You're always on Catra's side now." Bow said.

Adora shrugged. "It's not bad, though! It makes sense."

"Whatever." Catra rolled her eyes.

"Well, I'll pass on the feedback." Bow laughed. "So, what are your plans for today? I heard Thaymor could use some She-Ra help."

"I've been meaning to go there." Adora nodded. "What about you?"

"Entrapta said she wanted to discuss some communication infrastructure ideas." Bow frowned. "I honestly didn't follow everything she said, but I thought I'd call her since Glimmer's not here today."

"I'm sure Entrapta's been having a lot of fun with what was left of Horde tech."

"And with Hordak…" Catra said.

"And with… Wrong Hordak…?" Bow added, voice cracking.

They all grimaced at the same time, then burst out laughing.

"Please, guys, let's not think or talk about that…" Adora said, "specially during breakfast."

The rest of breakfast was uneventful. Catra wasn't that hungry, but she ate the muffin and some eggs. She stopped Adora from eating a *fourth* muffin because she knew she'd end up sick in ten minutes or so. It was incredible how Adora seemed to have gotten even hungrier than she'd been during the Horde. Maybe it was partly because of the whole She-Ra thing, but Catra suspected she would've been like that with or without a magic sword.

She was relieved Adora didn't mention anything about the previous night to Bow, or asked him about therapy. Maybe she'd forgotten about it already.

A guard came in when they were almost done, asking if Adora could help moving something outside of the castle. It seemed like something quick, so Adora agreed, not before checking with Catra first with a glance that she knew meant she didn't want to leave her alone. Catra nodded for her to go, since obviously it was fine for her to be alone. Bow left soon after, mentioning the call with Entrapta he had scheduled.

Catra considered going back to bed, but maybe a short walk would be nice. She headed outside, walking along the edge of the woods. It looked so much brighter and alive than it once was, and honestly still spooky. Catra preferred to walk through it with Adora

who was way more attuned to its magic. The morning light and the nature sounds and smells made her feel a bit lighter.

Distracted, she noticed it before she could react to it — quick steps in her direction, followed by something jumping on her.

Catra shrieked, as she was attacked by… a flourish of licks and meows.

"Melog!" Catra struggled to hold Melog back. "Calm down."

Melog slowed down and allowed her to sit up. She held its big face, scratching its jaw.

"I was wondering where you were." Catra said.

In its weird language that Catra somehow understood, Melog started telling her about all the adventures it was having with Swift Wind in the past few days, but came back running when it felt something was wrong with Catra.

"Nothing's wrong." Catra reassured it.

Melog spent so much time alone being the only alive and magical being on its planet that now it wanted to explore all of Etheria. And apparently it had become besties with Swift Wind in the process. Catra wondered if they could even communicate.

It kinda made sense, though, Adora had a magical talking horse and Catra had a magical talking alien cat. It'd be cute if the talking horse wasn't so annoying… but Adora loved him so much it made Catra like him a little bit too. Melog wasn't Catra's per se, of course. It was a free being, so Catra encouraged it to do things on its own if it wanted to.

"Wanna go take a nap?" Catra asked.

Melog nodded, nudging its head on Catra's hand.

Catra went back to their room. The daybed by the big window was the perfect spot for a nap.

It was still weird how quiet it was in the castle, no constant cacophony of cranking and cracking of old pipes, or who knew what else, like in the Fright Zone. The only noise was from the water fountain (which was a normal thing that Bright Moon rooms had apparently) that provided a nice ambient sound, and the occasional steps of someone walking by outside the room.

Melog occupied almost half of the daybed, but it was also a great pillow to lie on. It purred softly under Catra's hand. She imagined Adora would probably show up soon, but couldn't resist falling asleep.

She was not sure how long she slept for, but when she woke up she realized she was starting to get hungry, so it was probably close to lunch time.

The room was still empty apart from her and Melog. She wondered if she should go look for Adora. She had probably been swept into more favors from people needing She-Ra's help.

Melog started to move, so she sat up as it jumped off towards the door. She was so used to being the one with the best hearing around, it was funny how Melog noticed things before her. As the door clicked and started to open, Adora was surprised by an excited Melog jumping on top of her.

She fell to the ground with a yelp, whatever she was holding also falling around her.

"Melog! Do you always need to jump on me?" Adora laughed as Melog licked her face.

It then circled her and lied on top of her legs, purring happily.

“I missed you, baby, but can I get up from the floor now?” Adora petted its head.

Catra laughed at the scene.

“Melog said that Swift Wind said hi, by the way.”

Adora looked up at her as if just now noticing Catra was there.

“Aw, I miss Swifty.” She said, bringing a hand to her chest. Then, after a beat, “Catra, help meee.”

“What am I supposed to do?” Catra snorted.

“Tell Melog to get off me.”

“It’s not my fault it loves you so much.”

“Isn’t it attuned to your emotions? I think it is *specially* your fault, in fact.” Adora said, smugly. “It’s almost like you like me, or something.”

“Adora, we’re literally dating.” Catra said, blushing for no reason. The way Adora said that still affected her, as if, again, they weren’t literally girlfriends.

“Wow, how embarrassing for you—” Adora continued, but before she could say anything else Melog tackled her again.

Catra snickered. “C’mon, Melog, give her a break.”

Melog looked up at Catra, then back at Adora, considering it, then finally got up and joined her on the daybed again.

“Thank you.” Adora breathed out.

She picked two books from the floor and walked over to Catra, sitting at the edge of the daybed.

“What’s that?”

“I was doing some research.” Adora said, adjusting the books on her lap. “I think I know what we should do today, but we don’t have to if you don’t wanna.”

“What?”

“Well, I was thinking… we never did, like… a funeral.” Adora said carefully. “For Shadow Weaver.”

Catra flinched at hearing that name. Adora noticed, and put one hand over Catra’s.

“I don’t understand.”

“I thought if we did something like that then maybe it’d help us process stuff, you know?” Adora said. “Because in the Fright Zone we didn’t have anything like that, right? If a soldier died or went missing we were just supposed to pretend they never even existed, which is, like, so fucked up when you think about it…”

Catra slid her hand from under Adora’s and crossed her arms.

“She doesn’t… she doesn’t deserve a funeral. Or anything from us.”

“It wouldn’t be for her.”

Adora opened one of the books on her lap and flipped around the pages, looking for something, until she stopped with her finger going over a paragraph.

“Funerals and other traditions for the dead are primarily for the benefit of the grievers.” She said in her reading voice.

“You were researching about grief?”

Adora closed the book and blinked. “Well, yeah.”

“Adora…” Catra sighed, looking down at the floor, frowning. “This is not something you need to fix. You don’t need to fix me, or

whatever.”

Melog meowed and headbumped Catra, but she ignored it.

“I’m not—” Adora started, but paused. She put the books by her side and sat closer, hands gentle on Catra’s arms. “I’m not trying to fix you, Catra. You’re not broken.”

Catra met her eyes.

“Like I said, it’s not for her.” Adora squeezed her arms. “I think it could be good for you, and for me too. I think I need to process what happened too, and I would really like to do that with you.”

Catra uncrossed her arms and held Adora’s hands.

“And I’m sure you already planned everything?”

“Not really.” Adora smiled. “I just thought we could go to Mystacor since Glimmer is there, and learn what their funeral traditions are, and then we can decide from there.”

Adora looked at her earnestly. It had always been hard saying no to her.

“Fine, if that’s something you want to do.” Catra exhaled. “But weren’t you planning on going to Thaymor today?”

“They can go a few days without She-Ra…” Adora shrugged. “My girlfriend is more important.”

Catra smiled.

“I mean, you already saved the world and the universe, what more do they want from you?”

“*We* did all that!” Adora exclaimed, beaming and holding Catra’s face with both hands.

“I guess.” Catra muttered, cheeks warming.

Adora seemed to smile even bigger, right before throwing her arms around Catra's neck and toppling them over.

"Adora!" Catra laughed. Adora started giving her cheek kisses repeatedly. "What, you're Melog now?"

Adora laughed in between kisses, and then was interrupted by Melog jumping on top of them both.

"My lungs—"

The sudden weight crushed Catra, but they were just laughing harder now, and if that was the way she was meant to go, then well, she didn't really mind it at all.

Later that day Catra stood at the top of a cliff. She held Adora's hand firmly because they were *way* too close to the edge for Catra's taste.

She took a peek below them and only saw clouds.

The last and only time Catra went to Mystacor they had teleported there. She'd thought Adora was going to call Glimmer to do that again since that would've taken a total of probably a minute or two. Instead, Adora suggested they took the scenic route which was supposedly more fun. Catra had told Melog it could go back to its explorations and didn't need to go with them, but now she was starting to think that having it there to teleport them away would've been a better idea.

"So… you forgot the way." Catra deadpanned.

"What? No." Adora said.

She looked down at the clouds intently.

“Uh, this is clearly a dead end? Unless She-Ra can fly now, or something?”

Adora turned her head to Catra and smiled, eyes mischievous. She let go of Catra’s hand to tighten the straps of the backpack she had brought with her around her shoulders, then held her hand again.

“Trust me?” She gave Catra’s hand a squeeze.

“Yeah.” Catra said automatically.

“On three, we jump.” Adora got into a ready to jump position, looking back down at the a thousand feet drop vastness in front of them.

“Wait, what—”

“THREE!” Adora didn’t listen to her. She *jumped,* dragging Catra with her.

Catra screamed her lungs out as they were enveloped by clouds and then landed on a soft patch of grass. She kept herself crouched, still screaming until she realized she was ok and alive and not in free fall. There was some movement and the clouds started to dissipate— they were going up?

Adora burst into laughter as the world came back around them.

“Adora!”

Catra let go of her hand. It was a miracle she had not sinked her claws into her skin and torn her hand apart.

“Stand up! We’re on a flying mountain!”

Catra looked around slowly, adrenaline still running through her veins. She glared at the giggling girl in front of her.

“I’m going to kill you.” She said, then tackled Adora.

Adora yelped in surprise, but was still laughing at her.

“Ouch! You said you trusted me!”

Catra straddled her, pinning her on the ground of a flying mountain, which was a thing that existed.

“Maybe a little bit of a warning next time you wanna *jump off a cliff!?* You didn’t even count right!”

Tears formed on the corners of Adora’s crinkly eyes as her giggles died down.

“Okay, that was my bad, sorry, I got excited.” She sighed. “I thought of doing a countdown but I had already said to jump on three, so I got confused.”

There was a big thud and a sudden stop. Catra tensed, and Adora used that moment to push her off and get up. She then extended a hand for Catra, who took it.

Adora pulled her close without letting go.

“C’mon, don’t be mad at me.”

Catra could feel her breath over her mouth. Her eyes flickered down to Adora’s lips before staring back at her eyes. That made Adora’s smug expression go away.

“You’re lucky you’re cute.” Catra said.

She leaned in, then stopped when Adora fluttered her eyes closed.

“C’mon, let’s go.” Catra said.

Adora opened back her eyes.

“No kiss?” She pouted.

Catra smirked as she walked off.

She couldn't resist her old habits of revenge. At least that just meant some teasing and messing with Adora, not starting wars and what not anymore.

"You're so mean!" Adora said behind her, quickly catching up to her.

Catra stopped, taking in the view of Mystacor. When she had last been here it had been nighttime, and they'd been too preoccupied in not being caught to admire the surroundings. Now, with no threat of brainwashed sorcerers wanting to murder them, Catra could see how beautiful that place was.

"It's so cool, right?" Adora said.

They started to make their way up the stairs. Some young sorcerers that were practicing magic around the gardens stopped when they spotted them to wave hello. Some others just looked curiously as they were going from some place to another.

Mystacor didn't look as if it had been through any destruction, at least from the outside, which made sense as it was a floating island. Catra doubted the Heart of Etheria almost exploding had done any impacts to it as it did to other places.

At the entrance of the main building, Glimmer's aunt awaited them with a big smile.

"Adora! Catra!" She took quick steps to hug them both and give them each a peck on the cheek.

Catra tensed, still not used with how affectionate the adults around them were, although it wasn't all that bad.

"Casta!" Adora greeted her. "How did you know we were here?"

"A little bird came running to me to tell me we had visitors." She looked behind her at the doors of the building. Behind one of

them, a little girl peeked curiously at them. She blushed at the attention. “She’s a big fan of She-Ra.”

“Hi!” Adora waved excitedly at her.

At that, the little girl ran off inside.

“Oh.” Adora’s hand dropped. “Did I say something wrong?”

Catra laughed.

“You used to have that effect on me too, you know?”

“Oh, Catra!” Castaspella suddenly exclaimed. “This is your first time here, right? Apart from, you know, the night we were looking for the failsafe.” She looked worriedly at them for a second, remembering that day.

“Yeah.” Catra said. “Adora wanted me to come visit with her.”

“Yes, yes, that’s wonderful.” Castaspella clapped her hands together. “We have to do a tour then!”

“I can show her around!” Adora said. “We don’t wanna take away from your time—”

“Nonsense!” Castaspella said, gently bringing Catra forward with a hand on her shoulder. “There’s so much to see! Follow me, dear.”

Catra shared a look with Adora, who just shrugged apologetically. Catra grabbed her hand so that they could at least walk together.

Castaspella wasn’t lying when she said there was so much to see. She took them to all the historical spots, and talked enough for the three of them. Catra imagined they probably never got tourists around here, since it was shielded in a magic bubble that made it invisible, and on top of that you had to get on a secret *flying mountain* to access it, so Castaspella was having a blast

giving them a detailed tour. It was at least interesting to get to know about that weird place.

After going through most of outdoors and inside of big buildings, Castaspella walked them by a corridor and pointed at a door.

“And that is where the catacombs are located, as we don’t have space for a graveyard outside as you’ve probably noticed. Up next on the end of this corridor—”

“Wait.” Adora stopped. “Could you tell us more about it?”

Castaspella turned around to face them.

“About the catacombs?”

“Uh, yeah, we were curious about Mystacor’s funeral traditions.” Adora said.

Castaspella tilted her head.

“We’ve been learning about the different cultures in Etheria. You know, since the war ended…” Catra said, trying to not make them look weird. “Funerals was a topic we came around recently. But we’re curious about other things about Mystacor, too, of course. This tour’s been wonderful to learn all about it.”

Castaspella beamed at that.

“Of course, of course. The Horde did not teach you cultural things, I’m sure.” She said.

She proceeded to tell them a brief explanation of how a typical funeral is like. It was enough information for them to take it from there later, and it wasn’t anything too complicated or fancy as Catra thought maybe it would’ve been.

“Thank you, that was very interesting.” Adora said.

“Of course. Now let’s go to the next room, shall we?”

They resumed walking, but Castaspella's monologue was interrupted by a cloud of sparkles in front of them.

"Adora! Catra!" Glimmer appeared from the cloud, and ran to hug them both. "I missed you two!"

"We saw you yesterday, Sparkles." Catra grunted, struggling to breathe. Why did everyone in this planet always hugged her so tightly?

"We missed you too!" Adora said.

She let them go.

"Where's Bow?"

Castaspella cleared her throat loudly. "Glimmer, we were halfway into a tour!"

Halfway?

"Oh, I'm sorry, auntie." Glimmer turned around to her. "But, you see, Catra's never been here before, and I'm sure you already showed them so much, and I know they'd love to go see the beach, too, before it gets dark."

"You'd be happy to know they are actually very interested in my tour and learning about our culture. You should take more after your friends, Glimmer." Castaspella put her hands on her hips. "But if you *really* can't wait to go to the beach, then well—"

"Thankyouloveyouauntie—" Glimmer spluttered as Catra saw the world disappearing in sparkles, then suddenly they were outside.

Teleportation still made her a little nauseous.

"I didn't know you two were coming! I could've teleported you from Bright Moon." Glimmer said.

“I wanted to show Catra the flying mountain!” Adora said, then chuckled. “She freaked out.”

“Don’t you start again.” Catra pointed at Adora, who showed her tongue at her.

Glimmer smiled fondly at them.

“That makes sense. Why didn’t Bow come with you? I miss him.”

“He mentioned something about Entrapta and infrastructure, I think?” Adora said.

“Oh, right, I remember.”

“So, where’s the beach?” Catra asked.

Glimmer gestured around. “Uh, here.”

There was no sand, and certainly no ocean, which made sense since they were flying in the sky. The clouds did move weirdly in and out, in a wave like motion, though.

“Uh.”

“Okay, it’s not a *beach* beach like in Salineas, I guess, but it’s a Mystacor beach! We can lounge here and watch the moonset.” Glimmer said. “I mean, if Adora can relax for more than a minute.”

“Hey! I’m getting better at it.” Adora put an arm around Catra’s shoulder. “Catra helps.”

They enjoyed the beach as the moons set, talking about Mystacor. Glimmer told them to join her and Micah for dinner, but there would still be a little while as they were planning to cook together. Adora then suggested for the two of them to go check out the

steam grotto, so they headed there, after making a stop to change into bathing suits and robes.

They entered what looked like a huge cave, full of bodies of water and waterfalls, and certainly a lot of steam. It was very warm.

“Wow.” Catra said. “How’s this floating island a real place?”

“Right?” Adora said as she removed her robe. “If I lived here I’d come here every day.”

Catra stared at her as she dropped the robe. She used to steal glances at Adora all the time, always afraid she’d notice, or worse, someone else would and she’d get in some sort of trouble. She didn’t have to worry about that anymore.

The years away from the Horde had done well to her. She’d always been lean and still was, but her ribs weren’t visible anymore, she looked healthier than she had ever been, and with even more muscle — her stupid shredded abs more shredded too.

“What?” Adora asked.

Catra met hers eyes. A pink blush spread through Adora’s cheeks. Catra didn’t care about getting caught by her anymore.

“Is it hot in here or is it just you?”

Adora giggled, rolling her eyes, blushing more.

“Shut up. Like you don’t see me like this all the time now.” She stepped closer to Catra and tugged at the collar of her robe. “C’mon.”

“Well, it’s a nice view.” Catra said. “Are you trying to undress me? We could’ve just stayed in the guest room, but here works too, I suppose.”

“This is a public space.” Adora smiled, starting to remove Catra’s robe. She let her.

“I mean, it’s empty…”

The robe fell to Catra’s feet and it was Adora’s turn to stare. She placed her hands around Catra’s waist and stepped even closer.

“Glimmer would *sooo* kill us.”

Catra brushed her fingers against Adora’s bare arm, slowly tracing a path up to her shoulders.

“Only if she found out...”

“And she’d probably ban us from Mystacor.”

“Would she?”

“But,” Adora swallowed, eyes fixed on Catra’s lips, “well, I guess making out would be fine…”

“Oh?”

“Unless you’re still mad at me, and will keep me punishing me by depriving me of kisses?”

“Is that really a punishment?” Catra laughed, bringing a hands up to cup Adora’s jaw.

“The cruelest of them all.” Adora nodded.

Catra took that as an opportunity to close the distance between them.

Adora kissed her open-mouthed, hungry, like the few hours since they had last kissed had truly been too long of a torture. She hooked one arm around Catra’s waist, bringing her impossibly closer, as her other hand moved up her body to the back of her neck, giving Catra goosebumps in spite of the warmth of that place. Catra sighed into the kiss, wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck, pressing their bodies closer.

Suddenly, Adora pulled away.

“But also,” she breathed, “we don’t have to.”

Catra, dazedly fluttered her eyes open, having already forgotten what they were talking about.

“Uh?”

Adora’s face was flushed, looking breathless and earnest, and impossibly gorgeous.

“Make out— I mean, we didn’t come to Mystacor for *this…*” She said, sheepishly. ”How are you doing, by the way?”

Catra blinked, then let out a dull heavy breath.

“Sorry. I ruined the mood.” Adora said.

Catra snorted.

“Wanna get in the water?”

Catra wanted to kiss her again, but she nodded, and let Adora lead them to one of the pools.

The water was hotter than she thought it’d be. It almost hurt to get in the pool, but her body quickly acclimatized to it as she sat down. It almost felt like she was being hugged by all directions.

“Woah.”

“Isn’t it so nice?” Adora asked, sliding down and looking like she was melting.

Catra snuggled closer to her.

“How are *you* doing? You are always checking in on me, but hasn’t all of this… you know, affected you too?”

“Of course it has.” Adora said.

“You just seem so… well adjusted?” Catra wasn’t sure how to talk about this without bring up old wounds. “Do you miss her too, or am I the only fucked up, crazy person around here?”

“You are none of that!” Adora shook her head, reaching for her hands. “You know she messed me up too.”

Catra nodded.

“And I didn’t want her to die.” Adora frowned. “I didn’t want anyone to have to die! I should’ve been able to save everyone—”

“That’s not your job.”

Adora scrunched up her face.

“It wasn’t my fault she chose to save us, I guess. Which is crazy because, you know, that’s *Shadow Weaver.* She only cared about herself, and power and magic.”

“Yeah…” Catra frowned. “I still don’t understand why she said all of those things at the end.”

A few words wouldn’t change the years and years of abuse, but hearing her saying that she was proud of Catra— just the thought of that brought tears to Catra’s eyes again. Maybe she had been proud of her, but why would it matter if she had never said it before? Or showed it? How many times had Catra tried to prove herself to her, to show her she was worth of love, only to not get anything back that wasn’t abuse or abandonment?

If some part of her ever did love Catra it wasn’t in a way that made sense.

Adora brought her hands up to cup Catra’s face, wiping at the tears that inevitably fell from Catra’s eyes. She wasn’t gonna cry again like she did on the previous night. She felt more in control of her emotions.

“She only saved us because that was the only way to free the magic. I wasn’t gonna do it without you. So she did what she had to do, as she’d say, I suppose.” Adora looked angry suddenly, then her expression softened again. “And of course I was sad. I went back to the crystal castle the other day and found her broken mask there, and being there made me cry a lot.”

Catra blinked. “You didn’t tell me.”

“I thought if it made me cry like that, it’d make you sad too, and I didn’t wanna do that.”

“Adora…” Catra said, brows furrowed.

She took Adora’s hands in hers, bringing them down from her face and to hold them in the space in between them.

“You don’t need to play the hero with me anymore. I don’t want you to feel sad and not tell me.”

“I know.” Adora looked down. “I’m sorry. I just knew it’d be a delicate topic, and you were so happy…” she looked back up, face full of fondness. “I had never seen you that happy and for so long, you know? I didn’t want to ruin it.”

Catra blushed. She thought to say *for better or for worse remember?* Except they weren’t *married* and had never said those vows to each other, (except in a dream Catra'd had the night after Glimmer made them watch a stupid play about a love story that ended with a wedding). The memory of that dream made Catra blush harder.

Adora stared at her with a curious look in her eyes.

“You weren’t gonna ruin it.” Catra explained. “We can be happy together, and sad together, and all the other emotions, too.”

“I know, but I was fine after.” Adora smiled. Catra raised an eyebrow. “Really. I’ve spent way more time away from her and the Horde than you did. I think that made me able to distance

myself and start healing emotionally, you know? I think I started to break free from her here in Mystacor, actually, when she sent her shadow minions and almost killed all the sorcerers."

"Oh."

"Yeah, it was pretty traumatizing… she made me think I was crazy and having hallucinations but I was able to step against her for the first time in my life."

"I remember that day…" Catra looked down, ashamed. "She made me guard the door while she did all that. Then I found her passed out on the floor and had to drag her myself to her room. She never even said thank you, and later blamed me for things going wrong."

Adora scoffed. "She sucked."

"Well, yeah." Catra snorted.

"But what I'm trying to say is… I wasn't planning to keep her in my life, our lives, after everything was done. In fact, I was gonna try to keep her as far away as possible, because she was still trying to mess with our heads, and I wasn't gonna accept that anymore."

Adora had that determined look in her eyes Catra had seen so many times. She wasn't going to let Shadow Weaver get in between them anymore, and that made Catra's heart full.

She looked at Catra more carefully.

"So I can't say that I miss her, but it's okay that you do."

"I don't— I don't want to."

"Healing takes time, and I'll be with you during all of it, okay?"

Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's neck and buried her head in it. Adora held her, arms strong and comforting around Catra.

She felt dumb and weak for missing someone like Shadow Weaver, after everything, but Adora understood her and didn't have an ounce of judgment about it. That was comforting.

She didn't have to feel ashamed. If time helped Adora then it could help her too, she thought, and she didn't have to do it alone.

"Thank you." Catra said.

"For what?" Adora rested her head on top of Catra's.

"For being you."

They stayed like that for a while. Catra tried to resist it, but she felt so relaxed that she ended up falling asleep.

She woke up with Adora moving suddenly, startled by something.

"Guys? Are you decent?" Glimmer said from somewhere behind them.

"Uh?" Catra asked, confused.

"Yes, Glimmer," Adora yawned, "we fell asleep."

"Oof, okay, I was covering my eyes just in case." Glimmer said, approaching them. "I didn't want a repeat of—"

"Okay—" Catra hissed, face flushing, "we get it."

They had to quickly come up with a rule of always knocking before entering Adora and Catra's room, and *never* teleporting in unannounced. Honestly, Glimmer set herself up for that incident, and she immediately teleported away, but it still embarrassed Catra tremendously.

Adora laughed, slowly detaching herself from Catra, and sitting by her side, one arm still around her shoulders.

“What’s up?” Adora asked.

“Dinner’s gonna be ready soon so I wanted to let you guys know.” Glimmer said. “I’m also gonna go pick up Bow so we can all have a big Mystacor dinner together!”

“Good idea!” Adora smiled. “We’re gonna go get ready then.”

“Okay. By the way, Catra, you look sooo cute in a swimsuit—”

Catra groaned, blushing again, then splashed water in Glimmer’s direction, who teleported away just in time as the sound of her laughs faded away.

“Sparkles…” She grunted.

Adora giggled, always amused when Bow or Glimmer called Catra cute, which they loved doing, probably because Catra still hated it. How dared they? She could claw their faces off, but if she told them that they’d probably say her claws are cute too, or some shit like that.

“She’s right.” Adora said, reaching for Catra’s face to squeeze her cheeks. “You’re soooo cute.”

“Stop it...” Catra tried to shove Adora away with an elbow.

“Ouch, okay, okay,” Adora raised her hands up, “but you like it when I say it, admit it.”

“Pfft, can we go now?” Catra asked, giving up. She would never win this battle.

Later, after showering and getting ready, Catra sat at a big dinner table at a dining room of the palace.

“I’m so glad all of you are joining us for dinner.” Micah said to everyone at the table.

Catra sat next to Adora who was next to Castaspella. Across from them sat Bow, Glimmer, and Micah.

“I’m sad I missed the walk here with you two.” Bow said to Adora and Catra. ”You should’ve told me you were coming!”

“We didn’t want to bother you. It was a bit of a last minute decision.” Adora explained.

“What did Catra think of the floating mountain?” He asked, anticipation in his eyes.

“Oh, she *looooved* it.” She said, irony in her voice, before bursting into giggles.

Catra rolled her eyes, suppressing a smile.

“If Bow was there he would’ve me warned about it.”

“Well, now I feel like I’m missing an internal joke.” Bow pouted, with the saddest eyes in all of Etheria on his face.

“Adora threw me off the cliff,” she stared with serious eyes at him, “no explanations.”

Bow gasped.

“I did not!” Adora elbowed her. “I jumped and took you with me, that’s very different.”

Bow gasped again as everyone laughed.

“Adora, you should’ve told her how it worked first!” He said.

“I don’t think she would’ve believed me until she saw it…” Adora said.

Catra considered it, shrugging a shoulder in response.

“I’m glad you all arrived in one piece.” Micah chuckled. “I’ve been wanting to spend more time with Glimmer and her friends after, you know, everything.”

“I’m so happy we’re all here!” Glimmer exclaimed. “We made some dishes that we used to do all the time with my mom. Please help yourselves.”

Catra kept her eyes on her food, slowly taking bites of it, as the people around conversed. When it wasn’t just her and Adora, or the two of them with Bow and Glimmer, she still felt like she was intruding and shouldn’t really be there. Specially as they kept mentioning their memories with Glimmer’s mom. Catra never even met her. All she knew of her were the caricatures from Horde propaganda showing her as an evil demon, and a far away angelic figure that she saw when she tried to invade Bright Moon.

Adora noticed her uneasiness and reached for her hand from under the table. That forced her to have to keep eating with her left hand, which she didn’t seem to mind.

“So are you enjoying Mystacor, Catra?” Micah asked, when everyone was just about finishing up eating.

“Me?” Catra’s ears perked up, a little startled. She wiped her mouth with a napkin before speaking again. “Yes, it’s a very unique place. The steam grotto is really nice, and I usually don’t even like water.”

“That’s always a visitor’s favorite, indeed.” Castaspella nodded.

“I miss it…” Bow said.

“We could go there now, if you’d like?” Glimmer asked.

“Ooh, yes!” Bow smiled. “Would you guys join us again?”

“We’re pretty tired,” Adora said, “but maybe tomorrow?”

“Of course, no worries.” Glimmer said.

“And I should go check if there are any kids up past their bedtimes.” Castaspella said, getting up to leave. “Have a lovely night, everyone.”

“Goodnight, and thank you all for joining for dinner!” Glimmer smiled, then reached for Bow’s hand. “Ready?”

He took a sip of his glass of water, then nodded, and they teleported away.

“And did you two enjoy the food?” Micah asked.

“Yeah, it was great.” Catra smiled.

“Literally so good!” Adora nodded enthusiastically. “Glimmer made some dumplings when we were in space, but these ones are even better with the proper ingredients.”

“I’m glad.” Micah smiled. “I know we haven’t got a lot of time to talk as I have been mostly here since the war ended, but Glimmer told me of Shadow Weaver’s passing. So I wanted to ask how are you two doing?”

Catra tensed. She didn’t expect him to bring that up.

“Um, yeah, it’s…” Adora tried.

“Weird?” Micah asked.

“Yeah, actually… is it weird that it’s weird?”

“Not at all.” Micah chuckled. “Glimmer has told you about Light Spinner, right? I’ve had to mourn her once, too, when I thought she had died.”

“Oh.” Adora said. “How… was that for you? If that’s okay to ask.”

“Of course.” He brought his hands together, thinking to himself for a moment. “Well… first, mourning who she really had been was easier, especially as a kid. She did something really bad and

suffered the consequences. But I quickly found out I also had to mourn the person I *thought* she had been before her betrayal. There is a lot of grief in being lied to. However, the hardest thing was mourning who I *wished* she had been, or how much I wished things would've been different, which I only managed to do as I got older and understood things better."

He took another moment to think.

"I was lucky to have a lot of loved ones around me for support. That is why I thought I'd check in on you two. I think only the three of us here truly understand what was it like with Shadow Weaver." He finished.

Catra remained quiet, with her eyes down, but she nodded when he finished speaking. Adora squeezed her hand.

"Thank you, your majesty." Adora said. "We appreciate that."

"Please, I've told you, you can call me Micah." He smiled. "And the two of you can always reach out to me whenever you'd like, alright?"

Catra nodded again.

"Now I should really get going to bed, but I hope you enjoy the rest of your stay here."

After dinner, Adora led them outside, to a patch of grass not too far from the palace. The grass was soft and chilly like the night air.

"I wanted to see the stars from here." Adora said, looking up from where they were sitting.

Catra looked up too. In Mystacor, above the clouds, the sky was completely full of the little light dots that still mesmerized Catra.

“Sometimes I can see all the constellations shapes, but it disappears quickly as if it’s a memory from a dream.” Adora said after a while. “I think it comes from the past She-Ras’ memories.”

“Like how you can understand the First Ones language?”

“I guess.” Adora hummed. “Every She-Ra before me has looked up at these same stars. It was as common to them as the grass and the trees are to us.”

“Getting philosophical?”

Adora snorted. “I was just wondering if they got this same feeling of awe.”

“I think they did.”

Catra stared up for a while.

“Do you still wanna explore space?” Catra asked, remembering how they talked about having one more best friends squad road trip.

“Yeah.” Adora turned to Catra. “But only if you still want to, also.”

“With you I’m down for anything.”

Adora smiled big, then hugged Catra, half tackling her, making them fall back on the grass. She laughed and kept Adora close, shifting so they could both still look up at the sky.

“Do you ever wonder where you came from?” Catra asked.

“Sometimes.” Adora sighed. “What about you?”

“I’m from this planet.”

“You know what I mean.”

Catra was taken to the Horde as a toddler, not as a baby like Adora. She used to have some blurred memories, but now they

felt more like a memory of having a memory. Her actual earliest memories involved Adora, and even those were blurry, but she couldn't really remember Adora *not* being in her life anyway. Her story was probably as ordinary as the other Horde kids: a survivor of some Horde invasion in some poor village somewhere. Maybe she'd had a family once, or maybe she'd always been an orphan.

"Sometimes."

It didn't really matter, anyway. Her home was right there in her arms.

"I wanna visit new planets and try their food." Adora said.

"Of course you're thinking about food again."

"I know my priorities, okay?"

"Which are?"

"Well, food. Meeting the natives and giving them magic." Adora hummed. "And having fun in the process."

"Wow, so no girlfriend? No little old Catra in the list of your priorities?"

"That's in the having fun part!"

"Woah, okay, I see how it is. I'm just 'fun', huh?"

"No! I didn't meant it like that!" Adora exclaimed. "I meant we'll all be having fun together in our space road trip— I thought you asked about the road trip priorities…"

Adora leaned up on her elbow, looking down at Catra.

"But if you wanna know what my daily priorities are…" she started counting on one hand, "waking up with my girlfriend, kissing my girlfriend, cuddling with my girlfriend, making sure my girlfriend —"

Catra reached for Adora's shoulders, laughing, and bringing her down over her.

"You're such an idiot."

Adora giggled against Catra's neck. "I'm your idiot."

They stayed there for a while.

Catra considered cancelling their original plan. They'd had such a nice day, she did't want to ruin it, but she also knew they could have good days over and over again.

She kept the time by the positions of the moons. It was quiet, and no one walked outside. Catra wondered if they had guards, or if they didn't think that was necessary anymore. The old calculating part of her brain wanted to keep a note of that, "*Mystacor has weak defenses",* but she had no use for that anymore, so she let it go.

"Let me know when you want to go." Adora said.

They made a stop at their guest room to pick up the backpack Adora had brought. From their room, the path to the catacombs passed through the corridor with the big sorcerers statues. The statue of Light Spinner stood as Catra vaguely remembered. Still in shadows and obscured as if it was burned. She stopped by it for a moment. She couldn't see the woman she grew up with in it, except maybe for the gesture of the hands.

"She had a whole life here before we were even born." Catra said.

"It's weird to think about it."

Catra nodded, and started walking again.

They reached the door that Castaspella had pointed to during their tour. Adora opened it slowly, as if afraid it'd be locked, but it wasn't.

Stairs went down in a circular pattern, the walls lit by evenly spaced candles. It was kinda spooky, but Catra had spent enough time in poorly lit corridors to no longer be scared of them.

The stairs led to a big cavern-like room with tall, arched ceilings. The room was lit by what looked like a waterfall of fire on a wall, but that she suspected was just an illusion. If this wasn't a serious moment she knew Adora would be making some joke about her jumping into fire again. There was a big wall with the ancient burial vaults Castaspella had mentioned, where the cremated remains of past inhabitants lied in. There were also a few tombs by a different wall, maybe of more important sorcerers of the past.

"We can find an empty vault?" Adora said, unsure.

Catra nodded and walked towards the big wall. She then wondered if they should've asked for permission to do that, and hoped they weren't being disrespectful. Many vaults had writings on them, but many were also unmarked. Opening an unmarked one out, it was like a stone drawer that fit in the squares carved in the wall.

"I brought—" Adora started, taking something from her backpack. Catra had a guess of what it'd be, and she was right.

Adora held the broken pieces of Shadow Weaver's mask. Catra reached for them. They were scratched, cracked, and burned. She swallowed hard, memories flashing back, of both that moment and of her most recent nightmare.

She gripped at the pieces hard, her claws probably leaving new marks on them. She felt suddenly as if she was out of herself, her hands weren't hers as they trembled in front of her. Her lungs

were tight, unable to fully breathe in and out, so similar to what Shadow Weaver's shadows would do to her.

She was, at once, that little girl being punished for entering the Black Garnet room, and that older self moments before pulling the portal lever, who wanted to follow in the steps of the one who left her and was punishing her for it, and all her other versions who got that same treatment again and again. She didn't deserve any of them.

Maybe this had all been a sick trick. Maybe she was there again, waiting to strike Catra whenever she put her guard down. Maybe —

Catra blinked hard as she felt a warm hand on the side of her face, moving her head up. She slowly focused on Adora, her muffled voice becoming clear again.

"—you with me?"

"Sorry."

Catra looked around. The light from the fire waterfall caused different shadow patterns around the room. No shadow moved unnaturally, though. The room was empty apart from them, she had already confirmed that when they entered.

Adora's other hand was on her shoulder, squeezing it reassuringly.

"It's okay, there's nothing to apologize for. Wanna try some deep breathes?"

Catra inhaled deeply, her lungs working freely. She relaxed a bit.

"Is it ok if I take this now?" Adora reached for the broken mask.

Catra nodded.

They didn't have Shadow Weaver's remains to put in the vault, so the mask would do. Adora put the pieces carefully in the

container, then pushed it all the way back in the vault's space.

And just like that, all that remained from the woman who raised her was gone. All that the world could see at least. The way Catra flinched at shadows, always double checking them, or the way she didn't quite fully trust anyone (apart from Adora), or so many other things, remained with her. Within her Shadow Weaver lived, in a way.

The markings on the other vaults looked like they were burned, probably written with the help of magic. Some also had fancier plaques, with longer texts written in them. Catra only had her claws, which were good enough to scratch 'S.W.' on Shadow Weaver's. She didn't want to write her entire name, or her old Mystacor name. She didn't want people to know they were giving her this. She never knew exactly how old she had been, so she only added the present year bellow the initials.

"We're supposed to light a candle." Adora said, looking around.

There were several unlit candles on a table by a column. Probably there for people who wanted to visit and mourn their loved ones buried there. Adora got one, used one of the lit candles on a wall to light it, and placed it in front of Shadow Weaver's vault. There was just enough space for the width of a candle. Catra noticed now some other vaults had melted candles in front of them as well.

"And now there's only an eulogy left." Adora said quietly.

"She doesn't deserve one." Catra scoffed. "She doesn't deserve any of this."

Old anger bubbled inside her, suddenly and without warning, her emotions catching up to her. Her eyes blurred as she swiped at the newly placed drawer, leaving claw marks on it.

"A lifetime of abuse and making me feel like the only way I'd be useful is if I fucked off her life and, I don't know, killed myself— for what? For her to die a hero? For me to still gather what's left

of her and put it on a loving place of rest?" Catra breathed hard, any semblance of control she thought she had for the past day now gone. "I wanted so bad for her to care, to give me even a minute of attention, to— *love* me. But I was never good enough for her."

She pressed the heels of her hands against her eyes.

"I gave you all of me, and it still wasn't enough—" Catra continued, the image of Shadow Weaver in her mind, looking down at her with disdain as she always did. "You just dropped me at the first opportunity you had, and somehow I still wish you were here to see how I don't need you anymore. How much better I am without you, and despite you." Catra shook her head. Her body trembled, and her voice was quiet and breaking when she spoke again. "Just when are you gonna stop haunting me?"

She felt Adora's hand on her arm, nudging her. Catra stepped closer towards her, and buried herself in Adora's embrace. She let herself cry in Adora's arms again, the anger gone as sudden as it had arrived, replaced with a heavier sorrow.

Slowly, her breathing calmed down. She was so tired of crying, but she felt lighter then, and Adora's warmth was grounding.

"How was that for an eulogy?" Catra asked, voice muffled against Adora's shoulder.

Adora sniffed. She pulled them apart, still holding onto Catra. Her eyes were teary as well.

She pressed a kiss to Catra's forehead.

"I think that was the eulogy she deserved." She smiled.

"Your turn now."

Adora sighed and nodded. "Okay."

She turned to face the vault, a hand holding Catra's.

"I'll never forgive her for what she did to us. We were just kids. I'll never understand why she pitted us against each other, or why she'd hurt you but not me, and would make it feel like it was my fault. I thought if I was better, if I behaved more, if I made you behave more, she wouldn't hurt you. I felt so helpless." Catra squeezed Adora's hand, hoping to return some of the comfort she had so patiently given her. "I had her attention and for so long I thought that was love… until I learned what love is supposed to be like, and I was able to see that all she did was use me."

Adora looked up, blinking away tears before continuing.

"And despite everything, I still wish I could've saved her, that I could've been a better She-Ra. She raised me to be the perfect hero only for me to fail her at the end. I wish she could see all that she's missing, because she doesn't deserve our love. She never did."

Adora frowned and let out a deep breath.

"I think that's all I got."

It was Catra's turn to tug at her to come hug her. Adora followed easily and let Catra wrap her arms around her.

"You didn't fail. You're a better hero than she could ever have dreamed of making you, because you did it yourself. She tried to break you and corrupt you but you're stronger than she could ever have hoped to be. You, *Adora,* not She-Ra, okay?"

Adora sniffed in response.

They held each other in silence for a long moment.

"I'm sorry I left you with her." Adora said, almost in a whisper.

"What— Adora, no."

"I left you all alone with her."

“Stop it.” Catra pulled them apart. “You gave me plenty of chances to leave too. I know you know that.”

Adora nodded. She had her eyes shut, mouth closed in a tense line. Catra could tell she was trying so hard not to cry, even though some tears had already escaped her eyes. She held Adora’s face with both hands.

“She couldn’t break me either.” Catra added.

Adora opened her eyes. Another tear escaped, and Catra wiped it with her thumb.

“You’re stronger than she could’ve ever thought, too.” Adora said.

Catra smiled.

“Let us leave her now, here. For good?”

“Yeah.” Adora nodded again, standing a little taller.

Catra glanced at the S.W. initials, now adorned by the impression of her own claws, and thought that was kind of fitting.

Back in the Mystacor’s corridors, the two of them walked quietly, connected by their hands. Catra felt calm, with a sense of relief. It had been harder than she’d thought this all was going to go, but also easier in a way. She was done, and the anxiety she had been carrying had also dissipated. She was exhausted, and suspected Adora felt similarly.

Catra heard footsteps and familiar voices, and knew who they were about to run into as they turned a corner.

Glimmer, Bow, and Adora all jumped at the sight of each other. Catra snorted at the scene.

“Oh my god, I thought it was a ghost.” Bow clutched at his chest with a hand.

“There are ghosts in Mystacor!?” Adora asked.

Catra wanted to say yes.

“Of course not.” Glimmer said. She rubbed Bow’s back, calming him down. “What are guys doing here?”

Catra could’ve asked the same thing to them, but she was too tired to joke around at the moment.

“We were taking care of some things.” Adora answered.

“Ok… vague…” Glimmer said. She paused, taking a better look at them and shifting into a concerned expression. “What’s wrong?”

“Nothing.” Catra said, in a sincere way, which just confused Glimmer and Bow more.

“Can I suggest…” Bow said slowly at first, then excitedly, “a best friend squad sleepover Mystacor edition!?” He cleared his throat. “Because now we’re both curious and want to know what’s going on.”

Adora looked at Catra, waiting for her opinion, but obviously wanting to say yes.

“Fine, whatever.” Catra smiled.

“Best friend squad sleepover Mystacor edition!!” The three of them exclaimed in unison.

“Isn’t it late to be screaming like that, you dorks?” Catra asked.

Bow and Adora covered their mouths with their hands.

“C’mon!” Glimmer laughed, and grabbed at them to teleport them away.

They ended up at the observatory, with lots of pillows to work as makeshift beds, a bottle of Mystacor wine, and an astronomy book Glimmer found somewhere after Adora and Bow kept trying to figure out what they were seeing in the sky through the big telescope. As exhausted as Catra was, this was fun, and she didn't want to go to sleep just yet. They told Glimmer and Bow about the impromptu funeral they've just had, and they were as supportive as she expected they'd be, even though they wished they could've joined and been there for moral support.

A wine glass in, and already tipsy, Adora proposed a toast. They all brought their newly filled glasses together, and waited for her to say something.

"First of all, can I just say how much I love all of you so much?" Adora started, already emotional.

Bow started tearing up. "I love you all too!!"

"And also— I'm so proud of Catra," Adora continued.

"C'mon…" Catra felt her face warming.

Glimmer and Bow both nodded repeatedly.

"It's true, I am." Adora suddenly moved closer to Catra and kissed her on the cheek.

"Adora… my arm is getting tired." Catra whined, flushing even more. She couldn't do this in front of Bow and Glimmer.

"Sorry, sorry," Adora giggled, "okay, and last thing…" she raised her glass higher, "fuck Shadow Weaver!!"

None of them expected Adora to just say that, so there was a second of stunned silence before they all burst out laughing.

Catra jumped up with her glass and shouted, *"Fuck Shadow Weaver!!!"*

Glimmer joined her, shouting the same thing even louder.

What surprised them the most and caused another bigger fit of laughter was Bow putting his glass down to cup his hands around his mouth to yell louder than all of them the same words. Catra had never heard him swearing before. She didn't know he was physically capable of that. She doubled over from laughing, sitting down next to Adora, who wrapped her arms around her waist.

"Bow, I didn't know you could say fuck." Adora laughed.

"Right!? I've only witnessed it once or twice." Glimmer said, sparkling a bit, like she was so excited she had just witnessed it again.

"I know many bad words, okay?" Bow said.

"Like…?" Glimmer asked.

"Hm… poop." Bow said.

They all laughed again.

"No, wait, I meant shit." Bow shook his head. "Whatever."

Catra sighed, "I love you guys."

The giggles turned into gasps.

"Really!?" Bow asked, tearing up once again.

"Oh my god!?" Glimmer exclaimed at the same time.

The two of them started dancing in circles, repeating, "Catra loves us! Catra loves us!"

"Hey, get in line, guys." Adora said, smugly.

“Please,” Catra hid her face in her hands, blushing again, “I can’t say *anything* to you people…”

Eventually, the chaos died down as sleep got the best of them. Catra shared a big pillow with Adora, half over each other.

“Goodnight.” Adora whispered, smiley eyes fighting to stay open.

Catra snuggled closer. “Goodnight, Adora.”

No ghosts visited her dreams that night.

End Notes

writing post canon catradora is so interesting bc they won't take their hands off each other... "aren't you the writer making they do that?" you may ask, well i'm simply a vessel they do what they want

idk if anyone still reads catradora fics but if you made this far thank you :-)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!